

Characterisation Techniques — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: 60 min

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NOTES, STRUCTURES & TECHNIQUE

DEFINITION

Characterisation is how a writer reveals what a character is like, without simply stating it outright.

4 WAYS WRITERS REVEAL CHARACTER — COPY THE TABLE

METHOD	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Action	What a character does, especially under pressure
Dialogue	What they say, and how (tone, word choice, what they avoid saying)
Thought/feeling	Direct access to their inner thoughts, given by the narrator
Others' reactions	How other characters respond to or describe them

DIRECT VS. INDIRECT CHARACTERISATION

Direct: the text states the trait outright ("she was generous"). **Indirect:** the trait must be inferred from actions/dialogue/reactions. Indirect is usually a stronger, richer answer to give in an exam.

SENTENCE FRAME TO COPY

"This is an example of [action/dialogue/thought/reaction] characterisation. It suggests the character is ____, because ____."

2 · PRACTICE — 4 PASSAGES, 20 QUESTIONS

EXTRACT A

Yusuf checked the fire escape map on his way into every new classroom, without really thinking about it any more, then chose a seat closest to the door.

- Which characterisation method is used here: action, dialogue, thought, or reaction?

- What trait does this suggest about Yusuf?

- Is this direct or indirect characterisation? Explain.

- What single word in the sentence suggests this is now a habit, not a one-off?

- Write one sentence using the technique's sentence frame to answer this passage.

EXTRACT B

"It's fine, honestly, I don't mind," Elena said, already refolding the blanket she'd just handed over for the second time that week.

- Which characterisation method is used here?

7. What does Elena's dialogue suggest about her real feelings, given her actions?

8. Why might the writer show her actions contradicting her words?

9. Is this direct or indirect characterisation?

10. What might this contradiction foreshadow later in a story?

EXTRACT C

Nobody asked Priya to double-check the accounts before the meeting. She just always did, quietly, before anyone else arrived.

11. Which characterisation method is primarily used?

12. What trait is suggested by "nobody asked" and "she just always did"?

13. Find one word suggesting she avoids attention for this habit.

14. Is this direct or indirect characterisation?

15. Write your own one-sentence inference about Priya's character, using evidence.

EXTRACT D

"Honestly, ask Marcus," the coach said, when a parent complained about the training schedule. "He's the only one who's never missed a session, rain or shine, in three years."

16. Which characterisation method is used here: the coach's words about Marcus, or Marcus's own actions?

17. What trait about Marcus is revealed through another character's reaction/statement?

18. Find the phrase that emphasises Marcus's consistency.

19. Is this direct or indirect characterisation?

20. Explain why hearing this from the coach (not Marcus himself) makes it more convincing.

Apply this every time: Whenever asked "what does this show about the character," name the method (action/dialogue/thought/reaction) before giving your inference — it proves you understand how characterisation works, not just what happened.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1. Action | 11. Action |
| 2. cautious/safety-conscious | 12. diligent/responsible |
| 3. Indirect — inferred from routine action | 13. "quietly" |
| 4. "any more" (habitual) | 14. Indirect |
| 5. Model: "This is action characterisation... suggests he is cautious." | 15. Any reasonable inference with evidence |
| 6. Dialogue + action | 16. Reaction (coach's statement) |
| 7. She minds, but hides it | 17. dedicated/reliable |
| 8. To show a gap between what she says and feels | 18. "never missed a session, rain or shine" |
| 9. Indirect | 19. Indirect (via another character) |
| 10. She may resent it later / burn out | 20. Third-party praise seems more objective/less biased |